



DEPARTMENT OF POLITICAL SCIENCE

Course Report: Political Science Analysis SK2121 Fall semester 2023

Frida Boräng

The course Political Science Analysis (SK2121) is a core course on the advanced level. It is the first course on the Master's Program in Political Science (MAPS) and the Master's Programme in Political Science: Environmental Governance and Behavior (MAPSE) and forms the introduction to these programmes.

Course coordinator is Frida Boräng, who is also responsible for the research area Comparative politics. The other teachers on the course are Lina Eriksson (Political theory), Adrian Hyde-Price (International politics), Victor Lapuente (Public administration) and Georgis Xezonakis (Political behavior). Elena Leuschner worked as Teaching assistant on the course and helped students with academic writing.

The idea behind the course is to present an overview of Political Science. The course is organized around five research areas – Political Theory, Comparative Politics, Political Behavior, Public Administration and International Politics. Each bloc consists of three parts - a "base" lecture, two "research front" lectures, and a seminar. The base lecture presents the background and development of the research area, as well as classical theories, concepts and findings. The research front lectures focus on selected actual research problems, based in current research. For each research area the students are presented seminar assignments in the form of three semi-selective themes or research problems which should be analyzed and discussed in a short research overview and discussed at the seminar, using the assigned literature. The examination of the course is based on each of these five papers and the seminars. An innovation for this year was that we added a voluntary "literature talk" between the lectures and the examining seminar, the idea being that the students would have had time to read most of the literature, but still be working on the written assignment. During the literature talks, students could come with their questions about the literature and discuss them together with fellow students and the responsible teacher. Another change from previous years, that was made in order to make the course more relevant for the MAPSE students, was to introduce more about environmental politics under the different research areas. The goal is that one of the elective themes for each research area should be on environmental politics but this was not fully implemented for 2023.

The course is examined through five research overviews, one for each research area. In addition to the research reports the student must make one oral presentation of their research report and actively participate in all five compulsory seminars to pass the course. The five seminar papers are graded Fail (U), Pass (G), or Pass with Distinction (VG) and awarded 3 credits each. Failed seminar papers have to be completed following the teacher's instruction in order to reach the Pass level. In

order to pass the course (G), the student needs to pass all the assignments. In order to pass the course with distinction (VG), at least 3 of the seminar papers must have the grade VG and the rest of the assignments have the grade G.

During the fall semester 2023, 44 students were registered for the course (3 of these had re-registered). Of the 44, 39 had completed the course by February 2024. 24 students received the grade Pass (G) and 15 students Pass with Distinction (VG).

The students were asked to fill in the course evaluation after the course was completed. Out of 44 students who received the evaluation survey, 29 students responded (66%). The survey responses are attached. In addition to the survey, the course coordinator invited the students to an evaluation seminar the last day of the course. The seminar was very well attended and the students provided very helpful feedback. Below are results and comments from the survey and the evaluation seminar.

In general, the students evaluated the course positively: 90% of the students assess the course as either *Very good* (35%) or *Rather good* (55%). When asked to what degree the course helped the student to reach the learning outcomes, 41% answered *To a fairly high degree* and 45% *To a high degree*. This was reflected in the comments in the survey:

I have never before, in any course I've previously taken, learnt as much as I have during these two months!

But some students felt that the overview-format of the course came at a cost:

There were too many different themes and topics being presented at once for me to gain an in-depth understanding.

This was also brought up during the evaluation seminar: some students found that five research areas was a bit much and prevented a deep understanding of each. Since the aim of the course is to give students a broad overview, we still plan to keep the current format while recognizing that it comes with a cost.

In the evaluation seminar, the MAPSE students brought up that although there had been significant improvements from previous years (based on the experiences of fellow students who had taken the course before them) more could be done to make the course relevant for MAPSE. For next time, we should therefore make sure that each research area offers an environmental theme that the students can choose.

When evaluating the different teaching activities, students were generally happy with the lectures (*Very good* 31%, *Rather good* 66%), and the seminars (*Very good* 45%, *Rather good* 45%). The literature talks were also much appreciated (*Very good* 54%, *Rather good* 25%). This was reflected in the evaluation seminar, where students asked for more time for the literature talks, and said that it was during those they learned most. Some comments from the survey:

Great! They gave a lot of clarity about the assignments and a deeper understanding of the literature.

I appreciate them and think it was useful, however I wish the structure was a bit more set as it appeared a bit unstructured and confusing for some parts of the course.

Based on this, we should keep the literature talks for next time, but we could work more on the format. This time the format was up to the individual teacher, although we communicated our experiences during the course.

The students were overall very happy with the teachers (*Very good* 62%, *Rather good* 35%) which was also reflected in the comments.

The teachers were excellent. Very high quality teaching and it was really noticeable that they are experts in their field. At the same time, the teachers were very supportive and you could feel that they actually care about you learning something and making the most out of the course. Thank you for that!

There was no question in the survey about the academic writing support, but from both the evaluation seminar and comments in the survey it is clear that this help was much appreciated by the students.

The students were more critical about the course literature, although most regarded it as *Very good* (21%) or *Good* (48%). The points of criticism concerned, first, that the connection between readings and assignment were not clear enough:

In some sections the basic literature did not seem relevant for the assignments at all, while in others they were very relevant.

Moreover, students found the course literature wanting in terms of diversity; both in terms of authors and topics:

A lot of literature from white men from the west. Diversity would be nice!

It would have been appreciated if perspectives from non-European countries were also provided. It was mostly Europe-based issues and perspective.

During the evaluation seminar, students also asked for more female authors on the literature list.

The examination in form of papers was generally much appreciated (*Very good* 43%, *Rather good* 50%), but some students reported that they would have liked more mixed examination forms. The students were very happy about the feedback they got on their work:

I was happy to receive in-depth feedback and actual recommendations on what to work and where I can still improve.

I really liked that we got a lot of feedback.

Really appreciated the helpful comments!

The organization of the course was seen as working very well for the most part (*Very good* 59%, *Rather good* 28%). The comments reveal that the students sometimes found it confusing that the teachers had somewhat different views on how to write the papers. We think it is important that the teachers are free to develop the assignments independently, but each of us could do more to clearly explain during the lectures how we think about the assignment.

When it comes to workload, 48% find it OK, but 45% think it is somewhat too demanding. 24% reported that they worked more than 40 hours per week. At the same time, 31% reported that they worked only 21-30 hours per week, and a few even less than that. Students also expressed that they did get a lot of support:

I am very grateful for the GU's warm welcome. I could really feel how all staff I came in contact with in this course deeply cared about the students' well-being, academically but also privately (in a sense of work-life-balance).

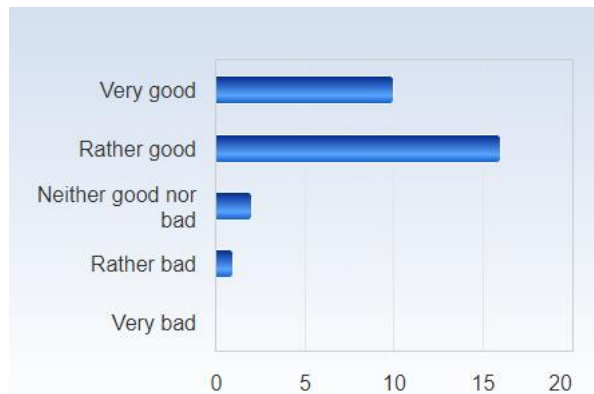
Based on this, it is not obvious that the course work should be reduced, but there might be reason to look over the schedule. Especially the first weeks of the course were seen as tough by some, since it was the start of the programmes and they were new to the university, city and even country. Adding a little more time for the first research area could make the start of the course and the programme even better.

SK2121 H23 Political Science Analysis

Respondents: 44
Answer Count: 29
Answer Frequency: 65,91 %

Overall, how would you assess the course?

Overall, how would you assess the course?	Number of responses
Very good	10 (34,5%)
Rather good	16 (55,2%)
Neither good nor bad	2 (6,9%)
Rather bad	1 (3,4%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	29 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the course?	1,8	0,7	40,5 %	1,0	1,0	2,0	2,0	4,0

After completion of the course the students are expected to reach the following learning outcomes:

Knowledge and understanding:

- have indepth as well as broad general knowledge of the main Political Science research areas**
- have gained insights of such a character that will make possible in-depth understanding and analysis of various Political Science problematics and issues by means of contending analytivcal perspectives and research methods**

Skills and abilities:

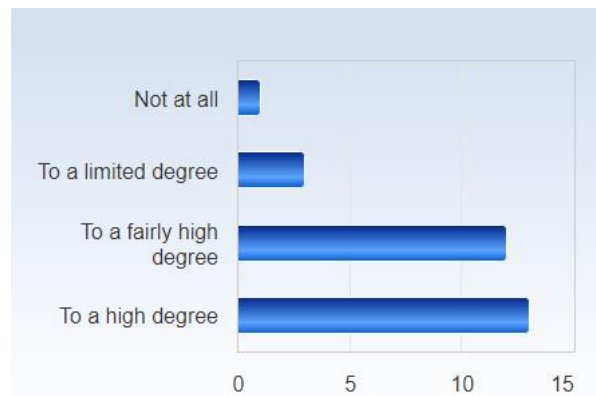
- Independently, at an in-depth level, organise, write and present orally and in writing short research reports with topics from the various Political Science research areas**

Judgement and approach:

- At an in-depth level understand and critically evaluate research based on the main Political Science research.**

To what degree the course helped you to reach these learning outcomes?

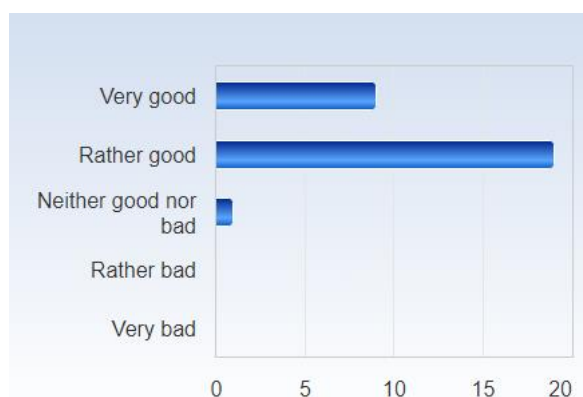
After completion of the course the students are expected to reach the following learning outcomes: Knowledge and understanding: - have indepth as well as broad general knowledge of the main Political Science research areas - have gained insights of such a character that will make possible in-depth understanding and analysis of various Political Science problematics and issues by means of contending analytivcal perspectives and research methods Skills and abilities: - Independently, at an in-depth level, organise, write and present orally and in writing short research reports with topics from the various Political Science research areas Judgement and approach: - At an in-depth level understand and critically evaluate research based on the main Political Science research. To what degree the course helped you to reach these learning outcomes?	Number of respon- ses
Not at all	1 (3,4%)
To a limited degree	3 (10,3%)
To a fairly high degree	12 (41,4%)
To a high degree	13 (44,8%)
Total	29 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coef- ficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quar- tile	Median	Upper Quar- tile	Max
After completion of the course the students are expected to reach the following learning outcomes: Knowledge and understanding: - have indepth as well as broad general knowledge of the main Political Science research areas - have gained insights of such a character that will make possible in-depth understanding and analysis of various Political Science problematics and issues by means of contending analytival perspectives and research methods Skills and abilities: - Independently, at an in-depth level, organise, write and present orally and in writing short research reports with topics from the various Political Science research areas Judgement and approach: - At an in-depth level understand and critically evaluate research based on the main Political Science research. To what degree the course helped you to reach these learning outcomes?	3,3	0,8	24,3 %	1,0	3,0	3,0	4,0	4,0

Overall, how would you assess the lectures?

Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	Number of responses
Very good	9 (31,0%)
Rather good	19 (65,5%)
Neither good nor bad	1 (3,4%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	29 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the lectures?	1,7	0,5	30,6 %	1,0	1,0	2,0	2,0	3,0

Overall, how would you assess the teachers?

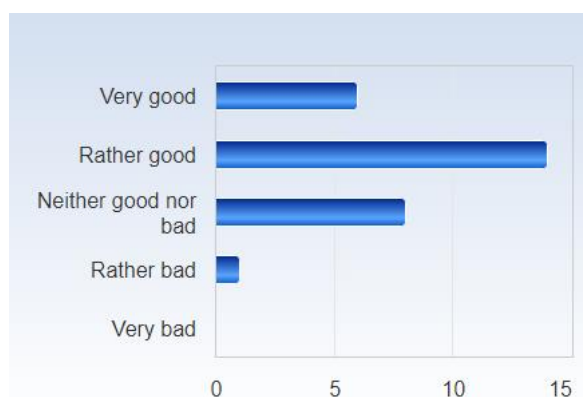
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	Number of responses
Very good	18 (62,1%)
Rather good	10 (34,5%)
Neither good nor bad	1 (3,4%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	29 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the teachers?	1,4	0,6	40,2 %	1,0	1,0	1,0	2,0	3,0

Overall, how would you assess the literature?

Overall, how would you assess the literature?	Number of responses
Very good	6 (20,7%)
Rather good	14 (48,3%)
Neither good nor bad	8 (27,6%)
Rather bad	1 (3,4%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	29 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the literature?	2,1	0,8	36,9 %	1,0	2,0	2,0	3,0	4,0

Overall, how would you assess the talks?

Overall, how would you assess the talks?	Number of responses
Very good	15 (53,6%)
Rather good	7 (25,0%)
Neither good nor bad	6 (21,4%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	28 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the talks?	1,7	0,8	48,8 %	1,0	1,0	1,0	2,0	3,0

Overall, how would you assess the seminars?

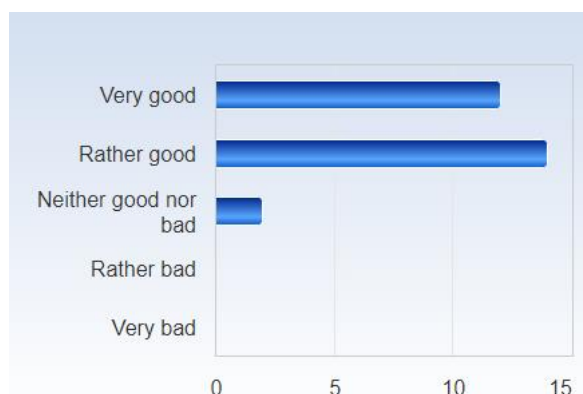
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	Number of responses
Very good	13 (44,8%)
Rather good	13 (44,8%)
Neither good nor bad	2 (6,9%)
Rather bad	1 (3,4%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	29 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the seminars?	1,7	0,8	45,0 %	1,0	1,0	2,0	2,0	4,0

Overall, how would you assess the examination in form of papers?

Overall, how would you assess the examination in form of papers?	Number of responses
Very good	12 (42,9%)
Rather good	14 (50,0%)
Neither good nor bad	2 (7,1%)
Rather bad	0 (0,0%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	28 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
Overall, how would you assess the examination in form of papers?	1,6	0,6	37,8 %	1,0	1,0	2,0	2,0	3,0

How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (information, schedule, administration)?

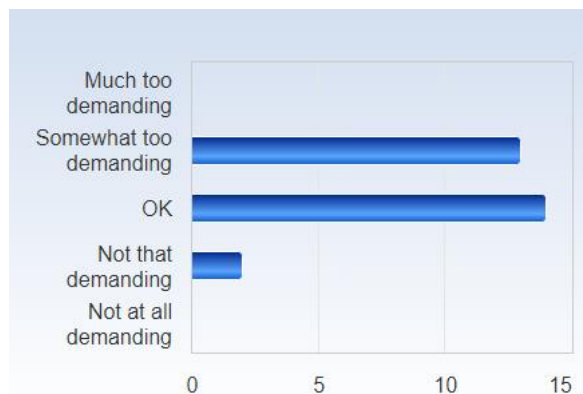
How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (information, schedule, administration)?	Number of responses
Very good	17 (58,6%)
Rather good	8 (27,6%)
Neither good nor bad	3 (10,3%)
Rather bad	1 (3,4%)
Very bad	0 (0,0%)
Total	29 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
How would you assess the organization of the course, including the information on Canvas (information, schedule, administration)?	1,6	0,8	52,0 %	1,0	1,0	1,0	2,0	4,0

What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:

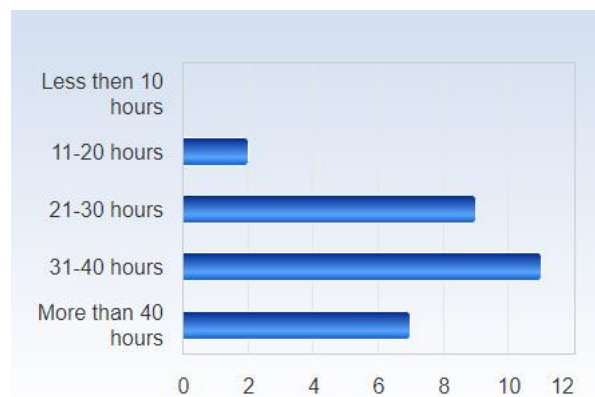
What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:	Number of responses
Much too demanding	0 (0,0%)
Somewhat too demanding	13 (44,8%)
OK	14 (48,3%)
Not that demanding	2 (6,9%)
Not at all demanding	0 (0,0%)
Total	29 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
What is your assessment of the amount of work you have been requested to carry out during the course? Do you consider the course:	2,6	0,6	23,7 %	2,0	2,0	3,0	3,0	4,0

On average, approximately how much time do you spend on coursework, both in and outside of the classroom, per week?

On average, approximately how much time do you spend on coursework, both in and outside of the classroom, per week?	Number of responses
Less than 10 hours	0 (0,0%)
11-20 hours	2 (6,9%)
21-30 hours	9 (31,0%)
31-40 hours	11 (37,9%)
More than 40 hours	7 (24,1%)
Total	29 (100,0%)



	Mean	Standard Deviation	Coefficient of Variation	Min	Lower Quartile	Median	Upper Quartile	Max
On average, approximately how much time do you spend on coursework, both in and outside of the classroom, per week?	4,0	1,3	31,4 %	2,0	3,0	4,0	4,0	6,0

Would you say that you had an “eureka moment” during the course, i.e. a time when you suddenly realized something that you previously did not understand or was aware of? If so, please make a short comment about it below.

Do you have any additional points of view you would like to express?